relief camps sheltering those displaced from Imphal. For over two and a half years, Manipur had been split into sealed ethnic enclaves—Meiteis barred from Kuki areas and Kukis from the Imphal Valley. A Meitei himself, the BJP MLA had done what perhaps no one else from his community had done—let alone any politician.

At Litan Sareikhong Baptist Church, he met refugees, heard their stories, and briefly lifted a young Kuki girl as cameras rolled. Kuki groups saw it as a touch pre-scripted and dismissed it as an "uninvited" and "opportunistic" stunt. But no one could deny one fact: he had indeed crossed an invisible boundary, and any outreach was better than none at all. Certainly better than congealed bad blood.

A HEALING TOUCH

Khemchand passed another frontier in his political life on February 4, when he took oath as Manipur's 13th chief minister—the first after a year of President's rule. In a state where ethnic violence took over 260 lives and displaced 60,000-odd in mid-2023, that job will call for all the five great *jungshin*, the mental qualities proper to a taekwondo master. Against the canvas of entrenched mistrust, with violence never too far away, even performative empathy may have a role there.

In a complementary move that's as symbolic as it is strategic, Nemcha Kipgen, MLA from Kangpokpi, was appointed as deputy CM. The driving idea is clear: she is the first Kuki-Zo in that role, and the first woman. Also, she's married to Thangboi Kipgen, chairman of the Kuki National Front, a militant group that's been under a Suspension of Operations (SoO) agreement with the Centre since 2008.

These groups have been among those at the forefront of demanding a separate administration for the Kuki-Zo territories in the hills, a position they describe as non-negotiable. Nemcha's elevation is expected to open a channel for dialogue on this demand.

Losii Dikho, the Naga People's Front MLA from Mao, comes in as the second deputy CM. On paper, with all three main communities of Manipur accounted for, the arrangement signals balance and inclusion. In practice, it carries deep political complexity and significant risks. Proof was handy as far afield as New Delhi, where Kuki-Zo groups gathered outside Manipur Bhawan on February 5 to protest their ethnic peer's elevation, calling it a betrayal of the community mandate.

Offering a healing touch to a scarred people was not the chief imperative behind Khemchand's appointment either; it was driven by constitutional and political pressure. On February 13, the second extension of President's rule—first imposed in February 2025, after former CM N. Biren Singh's resignation—would have run its course. Technically, with six-month extensions, this can run up to three years with parliamentary approval. But extensions beyond the first year require either an Election Commission certification that elections cannot be held or the status of a national emergency—both loaded options here.

Meanwhile, BJP MLAs were growing restless, unwilling to remain sidelined for much longer under central rule: elections are barely a year away. Thus it was that the Centre prepared to restore the elected government.

THE PARTY EQUATIONS

Agreeing on a chief minister was a tough ask for the BJP, though. Biren was unwilling to relinquish his claim, but no Kuki-Zo party MLA supported his return, even if he had a decent Meitei cohort behind him. Moreover, the central leadership felt reinstating Biren, or anyone he backed, would derail any reconciliation with Kuki-Zo party leaders and civil society.

In that context, Khemchand's selection is significant: he has been an open Biren critic. Though he served in his cabinet, he was never part of the ex-CM's inner circle, never a yes-man. Close to the RSS and acceptable across communities, including Nagas and Kukis, Khemchand, a Class 10-pass, emerged as a rare figure of consensus.

That's the quality that was in short supply for Biren, who is accused by the Kuki-Zo of targeting them through his campaigns against poppy cultivation, forest encroachment and illegal immigration. The former CM, a Meitei, denies this, citing records to prove neutrality. But a decisive rupture came with an 'audio recording', where a voice alleged to be Biren's discusses violence

THE BIG CHALLENGES

Top challenges before the new chief minister of Manipur

- **Restoring peace in a state scarred by over 260 deaths, displacement and entrenched ethnic divide**
- **Reopening highways, dismantling checkpoints, disarming militias, nailing the violence-accused**
- **Ensuring safe travel between hills and valley; resettling over 55,000 relief camp refugees**
- **Being able to govern independently despite former CM Biren Singh's influence; managing rivals within the BJP**
- **Winning the trust of Kuki-Zo MLAs and civil society organisations who remain sceptical of the new government. Five of the 10 Kuki-Zo BJP MLAs are against joining the Khemchand government**
- **Balancing Kuki-Zo calls for a Union Territory with Meitei opposition to any territorial division**